

Script:

(Illustration: Shekiba at the airport with her mother, surrounded by family and friends.)

Page 1: (Shekiba's POV) In the airport everyone is saying their farewells to my mother who is leaving for Canada. She had told everyone she is leaving, but why is everyone so sad, she is just going for work just as always?

Mother: (Hugging Shekiba) Sheki, eat well and learn to grow up without me, Okay?

Shekiba: (Confused) When are you coming back ?

Mother: I'm not coming back my dear, but it is you who will join me soon.

(Illustration: Shekiba adapting to life without her mother in Afghanistan.)

Page 2: (Mahsa's POV) Life without my mom had felt normal, she was always off for something. But, I always eat food with my mom, no one else? How will I eat? And when will I see my mom, it's taking longer than I had thought. It could take 6 years, Maybe more?!

(Illustration of her and her grandmother)

Page split: But at least I have my Grandma, to me she acts as a mother, My Grandma, The mother of my mother made the best Grandma in the world, she plays with me, even when she's not sure how, people have high academic expectations of me, not her, she only wants me to be happy, especially while my mother is absent.

(Illustration of Shekiba watching TV in Iran)

Page 3: (Mahsa's POV) *Six years old* I visited my father's family in Iran. It was lonely as I didn't go to school, Which I wanted to do. To me, school is friends not learning, But that's a little more fun than sitting at home watching TV .

(Illustration of her and her Grandpa running errands)

Page split: But at least I have my grandfather with me, he loves to play with me too and we always go outside to buy bread and groceries.

...this still isn't home, home is where my mother is, or at least where my Grandma is, but neither of them are here.

(Illustration of Shekiba celebrating her 7th Birthday in Afghanistan.)

Page 4: (Shekiba POV) Being back in Afghanistan should feel like home, but not enough it does, I just turned seven years old, without my mom, a year without my mom.

(Illustration of Shekiba in her school attire with her friends)

Page split: Being in the third grade is quite the big deal to me at school, so the teachers are quite strict on us, I mean I am a big girl now, am I?

(Illustration of Shekiba in Pakistan)

Page 5: (Shekiba's POV) I'm here in Pakistan for a few weeks, apparently this means that Canada is next, I am so excited! I'll see my mom and little sister, who i've been calling on the phone, she is cuter than ever.

(Illustration of Shekiba on Plane):

Page 6: (Shekiba's POV) Im happy, a happiness which i've never felt these past few years, Im happy and everyone knows it, it reflects like a beam. I can't wait to see my mother, whether she is in a dangerous or safe country, I want to be where she is, that's all I care about.

Page split:

Shekiba (To flight attendant serving juice: I love your shirt! (she says with a big smile)

Flight attendant: Thank you! You're in a great mood today it seems? (she says smiling back)

Yes, I am, I told her.

(Illustration of Shekiba sleeping at a hotel)

Page 7: By the time we reached Canada it was night and I was sound asleep
(Illustration of someone on phone)

Page split: In the morning we got a call from the front office saying that someone is downstairs waiting for us.

Father: Your mother is here

It felt like a dream, I couldn't believe those words

(Illustration of mother standing at the door with a happy yet emotional face)

Page 8: My mother, she's changed, her hair different, she is quite shorter... or am I taller? But what hasn't changed was her smile and warmth.

Page split: (Illustration of Shekiba in mothers arms, hugging and crying)

(Illustration of Shekiba's Little sister)

Page 9: The first person I saw was my little sister, Asal. She looked just like the pictures, she is only 3 years old. At first she didn't understand that I was her sister, not her guest. She got the idea once I pointed at myself going "Sis" with my limited english. She was over the moon to know she had a sister. She showed me my new room and her toys.

(Illustration of Shekiba's extended family)

Page split: The first place we had visited was my Uncle's house, gathered with my aunts and cousins waiting to see me again after so long, and a few that I haven't met, Morsal, she was my age and my immediate best friend /confidant. Of course Asal was going around claiming me to everyone.

(Illustration of Asal talking to relatives)

Asal: Hello, THIS IS MY SIS!

She does this to strangers in public as well

(Illustration of Shekiba's and her mom)

Page 10: I felt quite strange living with my mom at first, calling her mom was a struggle when at the time it felt like I was staying over with my aunt, as much as I missed her, I'm not quite familiar with her anymore.

(Illustration of Shekiba's beside her mother while she writes)

Split page: She did not let the time between us get in the way, she put all the effort into figuring out who I've grown into. She had asked me to write down my hobbies. Am I athletic or artistic? What are the things I'm interested in and what dresses and clothes do I wear? All enhancing my own identity.

(Illustration of Shekiba walking outside surrounded by people of all cultures)

Page 11:

Before coming to Canada I had always thought that it was only Canadian people, I thought I would forever feel like an alien living there, but when I go outside I see people from different countries, speaking different languages. If these people are Canadian, Then I must be Canadian too?

(Illustration of Shekiba at School, Another kid trying to interact)

Page 12:

It's hard to make friends when you don't know English. A boy came up to me today trying to talk to me. With no response he started using his hands to talk, sign language? I'm not deaf, But at least someone is making the effort to be my friend. Only if they knew how talkative I am in my language.

(Illustration of Shekiba with teacher)

Split page: My mom is teaching me English everyday at home, so things are getting easier but as if that's not hard enough we have to learn french. Today my teacher asked me what the word for red was in French. I said Orange is the only colour I know yet because it is the same in english. To my surprise, I didn't get in any trouble.

(Illustration: Shekiba drawing a happy girl, the sun, and the clouds.)

Page 14:

My mother always wanted me to see the bright side of life. One day, she asked me to draw a girl, a happy girl.

Shekiba's Mother: (encouraging) Now, draw a boy beside her.

Mahsa: (surprised) A boy? Beside the girl? I didn't know boys and girls could be friends. It felt strange, but my mother explained that all friendships could be as wonderful as the sun and clouds together.

(Illustration: Shekiba writing positive affirmations on a board.)

Split page:

Next, she told me to write positive affirmations on a board. Every morning, I'd look at them and say them out loud.

Mahsa: "I have an amazing life," "Amazing teachers," she said. I could write about anything positive. "You can write you have an amazing mom, if you'd like," she added with a smile.

Mahsa: So, I started writing. "I'm great at drawing," I'd write. "Mahsa, you're beautiful too," she'd say, and I'd jot that down too. Writing these positive things about myself became a routine, and slowly, I started believing them.

(Illustration of Shekiba and her mom)

Page 14:

My mother had never forced the things I didn't want onto me, At times where I didn't want to talk, I didn't need to talk, At times I wanted to cry, I could cry, I had every opportunity to be me, before I didn't quite know what made me, "me" up until the moment I saw her again.

Split page:

(Illustration of Shekiba doing work)

I had become a person who would do the things I typically wouldn't like to do, Only because I initiated myself to, if it were any other way, I wouldn't do it. Nothing a person would oblige me to do would matter if I didn't want to do it. Some would argue that it's better, not everybody will wait on you.

(Shekiba a few years older living in happiness in Canada, with her community and family)

Page 15:

I can longer claim any place as home. I've made close friends and a community amongst myself the more I have uplifted myself. But the only thing that makes a country home is under the condition that my mother lives there, or even my Grandma who now lives with us here in Canada. Everyday since I've been living here is just as happy as the day I was on the plane.

My final words on this story and its significance:

This project contributes to civic engagement in Canada by creating material for empathy and understanding among young readers. By highlighting the experiences of an immigrant child, the narrative can help readers develop a deeper appreciation and admiration for the challenges faced by newcomers. With empathy comes a sense of shared humanity, implementing a more inclusive and welcoming attitude toward immigrants, starting with young Canadians.

Moreover, the story showcases the importance of supportive communities and familial bonds during transitional times. A theme that can also resonate with readers

of all ages. It promotes a sense of responsibility and solidarity within communities which also have higher immigration rates in Canada, due to the difficult circumstances in those countries. It may also encourage young readers to appreciate diversity, knowing there is a unique story behind everyone who comes to Canada so youth can actively participate in creating inclusive spaces for kids who are new to the country

Also, it emphasizes the importance of education and cultural exchange. Inspires curiosity about different cultures and encourages readers to engage with people from diverse backgrounds.

In essence, this book has the potential to spark conversations around immigration, diversity, and the importance of community support. By addressing these themes, it indirectly encourages civic engagement by promoting a more informed, compassionate, and inclusive society.